



How to Get the Best Quality Printouts

- Use original ink cartridges to prevent clogging, leaks and bleeding.
- Set the printer driver settings correctly.
- The best results will be achieved by matching the printer, printer settings, ink and paper.
- Handle inkjet papers like photographic papers, by the edges to avoid oil deposits and fingerprints.
- Be sure that you are printing on the 'right' side of the paper, that is, the coated side.
- Best image quality (sharpness and colour saturation) is usually obtained at the printer's maximum dpi setting.
- Set your printer for the proper paper type and weight. Fine art papers are heavier than ordinary inkjet or bond papers. If possible, set printer to thicker paper settings, or use the 'envelope' setting.
- Feed heavy/stiff paper one sheet at a time. Placing a sheet of plain copier/bond paper behind a heavy sheet sometimes improves the feed.
- Media settings on your printer determine how much ink will be applied to the paper. Thinly coated glossy films require less ink, while plain paper soaks in more. Coatings are designed to control ink absorption and spread, producing brilliant, sharp images with less ink.
- Allow ink to dry completely to avoid smudging. The time it takes to dry will vary based on the ink and paper quality used as well as the temperature and humidity conditions.

1/2 page V. AD

and because the contrast was poor, the printer was unable to reproduce the depth of field.

The Lexmark series of printers followed close behind the Canon S200SP, with the Z13, Z25 and the Z35 scoring 6.7, 6.8 and 6.8 respectively. Another good performer here was the Olivetti Artjet 12, which scored a healthy 6.6.

The HP Deskjet 656C was quite disappointing—the printout was washed out and there were patches of faded colour.

The printers in the mid-range segment showed much better print quality than the budget printers—all scored over 6 points, except the Sharp AJ-1100, which scored a poor 4.1.

The HP Deskjet 920C scored the highest (7.4). There was no smudging and the detailing was superb. It was one of the few printers that could show the leaves in the background in perfect detail. Skin colour too was close to the original photograph. The HP Deskjet 948C also did well with a score of 7.3—just a shade lower than the 920C.

To complete a hat trick of sorts, the HP Deskjet 845C also logged a score of over 7. The HP Deskjets were truly a class apart when it came to high quality photo printing—at first glance, it gives you the impression that you are looking at the original photograph.

HP logged the highest score among the high-end printers as well. The HP Deskjet 970CXi scored a whopping 7.9—the highest in this test. But most of the high-end printers failed to live up to their expected performance—none other exceeded the highest scores logged by the HP printers in the mid-range segment. The Lexmark Z65N scored a decent 7.1 and the Canon S4500 scored a neat 6.9. Both gave sharp and high quality prints of photos. What they lacked was true-to-life reproduction of colours, especially skin colour.

In the case of the Epson printers, the scores were inconsistent. The colour photo printouts had a lot of smudging and banding despite repeated attempts at cleaning the cartridges and reprinting